

DIGITAL SAFETY TEACH-IN

Digital Safety for Protests and Public Life

An introduction to facial recognition, secure communication, social media privacy and device security. No technical background needed.



Facial
recognition



Secure
comms



Social media
privacy



Device
security

What we will cover in 60 minutes

- | | | |
|---|---------------------------------------|--------|
| 1 | Why surveillance matters today | 8 min |
| 2 | Facial recognition at protests | 12 min |
| 3 | Secure communications | 12 min |
| 4 | Social media privacy | 10 min |
| 5 | Device security on Android and iPhone | 12 min |
| 6 | Recap, resources and questions | 6 min |

Surveillance of public gatherings is documented, not hypothetical

2,100+

AI-enabled cameras in Delhi Police's new surveillance network, linked to the C4I command centre inaugurated in February 2026. India has no dedicated law governing facial recognition.

2026

The Delhi High Court is hearing a challenge to the continuous filming of peaceful protesters at Jantar Mantar during the CJP protests. Reporting describes police face databases built partly from images of earlier demonstrations.

65

Internet shutdowns recorded in India in 2025, the most of any democracy. Worldwide, 2025 set a record: 313 shutdowns across 52 countries (Access Now).

The goal of this session is informed choice, not alarm. Most measures here take minutes, cost nothing, and are useful well beyond protests. They are simply good digital hygiene.

Sources: Tech Policy Press, The News Minute, The Hindu, Access Now #KeepItOn report on 2025 (published 2026)

Three questions before any safety decision



What am I protecting?

Your identity, location, contacts, photos, messages. Different things need different protection.



Who could access it?

Cameras in public, apps and platforms, anyone who briefly holds your phone, data brokers.



What happens if they do?

Consequences differ by person. A first-time attendee, an organiser and a journalist face different risks.

Safety is proportional. Nobody needs every measure in this session. Pick what matches your situation, and help others do the same.

Facial recognition at protests

IN THE NEWS

July 2026: a petition before the Delhi High Court describes protesters at the CJP demonstrations at Jantar Mantar being filmed continuously from permanent surveillance towers, and alleges footage of young protesters was used to threaten complaints to their parents and colleges. Delhi Police says AI cameras helped identify people accused of violence.

Tech Policy Press · The Hindu · India Today, July 2026



How facial recognition reaches a protest



How the technology works

1. Capture

A camera detects a face in a crowd, even partly turned or partly covered.

2. Measure

Software converts the face into a numeric 'faceprint' of distances and features.

3. Match

The faceprint is compared against databases: police records, ID photos, scraped social media images.



Where the footage comes from



Fixed CCTV networks and mobile police camera vans



Drones filming crowds from above



Body-worn cameras, smart glasses and press photography



Photos and videos posted on social media, searchable long after the event

Faces are not the only identifier: gait, tattoos, distinctive clothing and your phone's signals can also identify you.

Reducing what cameras can capture



Before you go

- Wear plain clothing without logos, slogans or distinctive patterns
- Cover identifying tattoos, birthmarks and unusual accessories
- A cap, sunglasses and face covering together reduce (but do not eliminate) recognition
- Tie back or cover distinctive hair



At the gathering

- Keep your face angled away from elevated cameras and drones
- Keep coverings on for the whole time. One uncovered moment is enough
- Step out of frame when others are filming or livestreaming
- Gait and posture can identify you too. Walking with a group helps



Rules on face coverings at assemblies vary by place and time, and restrictions can be imposed locally. Check what applies where you are. This session is not legal advice.

Photos travel further than you do

Images posted from a gathering can be matched by face recognition long after the event. If you photograph or share:



Blur faces before sharing

Signal's photo editor has a built-in blur tool. ObscuraCam (Guardian Project) blurs faces automatically.



Strip location data

Photos carry hidden metadata: place, time, device. Sending a screenshot of the photo removes it.



Delay posting

Posting after leaving avoids revealing your real-time location, and everyone else's.



Ask before you post

Other people's faces are their choice. Prefer wide crowd shots over close-ups of individuals.



Documentation matters. The aim is to document responsibly, not to stop documenting. For documenting safely, Tella (free, Android and iOS) encrypts photos, video and audio the moment they are captured, hides them from the phone's gallery, can disguise itself as a calculator on Android, and records the metadata needed to verify footage as evidence.

Secure communications

IN THE NEWS

2025 set a global record: 313 internet shutdowns across 52 countries, with India's 65 the most of any democracy. During the 2026 CJP protests, mobile internet was suspended in tightly geofenced zones around protest sites, and students turned to Bluetooth mesh apps to stay in touch when networks went down.

Access Now #KeepItOn report on 2025 · Tech Policy Press, July 2026



Not all messages travel the same way

SMS and phone calls

- Content visible to the network operator
- Records routinely stored and can be requested
- No encryption at all

Avoid for anything sensitive

Apps without end-to-end encryption

- Encrypted only on the way to the company's servers, and the company can read content
- Includes email, Telegram's default chats, social media DMs

Assume the platform can read it

End-to-end encrypted apps

- Only sender and recipient can read the content, not the app company
- Signal (recommended) and WhatsApp both use end-to-end encryption by default

Use these for coordination

Metadata still exists: even with encryption, who you message, when, and how often can be visible. Signal stores almost none of this. Most other services store more.

Five-minute setup that makes the difference



Signal (recommended)

Turn on disappearing messages

Chat settings or per chat: messages auto-delete after a set time. Less history means less exposure.

Set a Registration Lock PIN

Settings → Account → Registration Lock. Stops someone re-registering your number on their device.

Use the blur tool for photos

Built into the photo editor. It blurs faces before sending or posting.

Enable screen lock in-app

Settings → Privacy → Screen Lock: requires your phone unlock to open Signal.



If your groups live on WhatsApp

Turn on encrypted backups

Settings → Chats → Chat backup → End-to-end encrypted backup. Otherwise backups are readable.

Enable two-step verification

Settings → Account → Two-step verification: a PIN that blocks account hijacking.

Use disappearing messages

Available per chat and as a default for new chats.

Know that groups expose numbers

Everyone in a group can see members' phone numbers. Keep sensitive groups small.

Plan for internet shutdowns and blocks

India recorded 65 shutdowns in 2025, and suspensions around the 2026 CJP protests were geofenced tightly around protest sites. Prepare while the network is still up:



Install a trusted VPN in advance

A VPN can route around blocks on specific apps and hides your browsing from the network. Trusted options with free tiers: Proton VPN and Psiphon (built for censored networks). You cannot download it after the block starts.



Know what a VPN does not do

It does not make you anonymous, and it does not help when mobile internet is fully suspended. Free unknown VPNs may sell your data, so stick to reputable ones.



Make an offline plan

Agree meeting points and check-in times in person beforehand. Download offline maps. Write key phone numbers on paper, not just in your phone.



Agree a check-in buddy

One trusted person not at the event who knows where you are and when to expect contact.



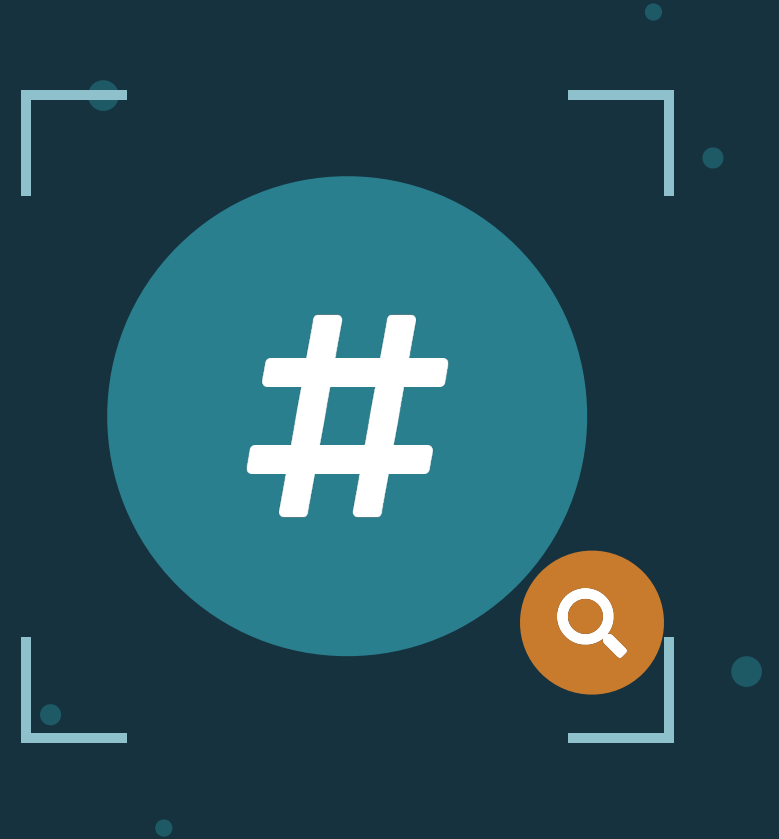
Mesh apps are a backup, not a safe channel. Students used Briar and similar apps during the CJP protests, but know the limits: Bluetooth broadcasting can reveal that you are present and map who is near whom. Some mesh apps have shipped with weak or unaudited encryption (researchers broke Bridgefy's in 2020, and early Bitchat flaws are documented). Range is short and delivery unreliable. Briar is the better-audited option, and only works if people install and connect in advance.

Social media privacy

IN THE NEWS

Investigations into Delhi Police's face recognition datasets describe a category labelled 'rabble-rousers and miscreants', built partly by harvesting images from earlier public demonstrations. A photo posted from one protest can follow a person to the next one, and to a job interview years later.

The Wire · The News Minute, 2025-2026



Your profile says more than any single post

Individually harmless details combine into a detailed picture, searchable by anyone, indefinitely.



Tagged photos build a face database of you, usable by recognition tools that scrape public images



Location tags and routine posts reveal where you live, work and spend time



Friend lists and follows map your family, colleagues and networks



Phone-number and email lookup can connect an 'anonymous' account back to you

Try it yourself

Search your own name, phone number and usernames in a private browser window.

What you can find, others can find. That is your starting point for cleanup.

The settings that matter most

Every major platform has these. Names differ slightly across Instagram, Facebook, X and Snapchat:

1

Make accounts private

Review who already follows you too. Private means little with unknown followers.

2

Turn off phone and email discoverability

Stops anyone with your number finding your profile. Often under 'How people can find you'.

3

Require tag approval

Review tags before they appear on your profile. You control your own face archive.

4

Remove location from posts

Turn off location tagging, and avoid posting in real time from sensitive places.

5

Hide profile from search engines

A setting on most platforms. It keeps your profile out of Google results.

6

Use 2FA and unique passwords

App-based two-factor beats SMS. A password manager makes unique passwords painless.

A 15-minute audit of these six settings covers most of the practical risk for most people.

Posting about a protest: a quick decision guide

Whose faces are visible?

Blur faces of anyone who has not agreed to be posted: organisers, bystanders, minors especially. Wide shots over close-ups.

When am I posting?

Real-time posts reveal your location and the crowd's movements. Posting later tells the same story with less exposure.

What is in the background?

Signs, landmarks and licence plates can locate and identify. Check the edges of the frame before sharing.

Am I naming or tagging anyone?

Tagging someone at a protest makes a public, permanent, searchable record of their attendance. Let people disclose for themselves.

Public visibility is often the point of a protest. These questions are about making exposure a choice, yours and others'.

Device security: Android and iPhone

IN THE NEWS

In the court cases that followed the 2020 Delhi riots, WhatsApp group chats recovered from seized phones appeared in police chargesheets. What is on a phone can outlive the moment it was written, which is why this section is about locking devices well and carrying less.

Widely reported in Indian court coverage, 2020-2022



Before you leave home



Lock it down

- Use a strong passcode: 6 or more digits, better with letters and numbers. Not a pattern, not a birthday
- Consider turning off fingerprint and face unlock for the day. A passcode cannot be pressed onto a sensor
- Update your operating system and apps. Updates patch known break-in routes
- Turn off location services, or at minimum live-location sharing



Reduce what is on it

- Back up your phone, then log out of apps you will not need: email, banking, cloud drives
- Charge fully and carry a power bank. A dead phone is no safety tool
- Memorise or write down 2 or 3 key numbers (lawyer, family, trusted contact) on paper
- Higher-risk option: carry a basic spare phone with only essentials on it

iPhone: four moves worth practising



1. Hard-lock in two seconds

Hold the side button and either volume button until the power-off screen appears, then press Cancel. Face ID and Touch ID are now off. Only your passcode unlocks the phone.

Works from your pocket



2. Emergency SOS

Pressing the side button five times rapidly hard-locks the phone, and on many models starts a countdown to call emergency services with an alarm. Check your model in Settings → Emergency SOS.

Know before you rely on it



3. Guided Access: show one screen only

Enable in Settings → Accessibility → Guided Access. Triple-click the side button to pin the screen to one app before handing your phone over. Use a different passcode than your phone's.

For showing a ticket or ID



4. Lockdown Mode

Settings → Privacy & Security → Lockdown Mode. Hardens the whole phone against sophisticated spyware such as Pegasus. It limits some features, so it suits journalists, organisers and lawyers.

For higher-risk users

Android: three moves worth practising



Lockdown mode

Enable once: open Settings and search 'Lockdown' (often under Display → Lock screen). Then: hold the power button → tap Lockdown. Fingerprint, face unlock and lock-screen notifications are disabled until the PIN is entered.

The Android hard-lock



Hide notification content

Settings → Notifications → 'Sensitive notifications': hide content on the lock screen. Otherwise messages are readable without unlocking the phone at all.

Takes 30 seconds



Block unknown app installs

Settings → Apps → Special app access → Install unknown apps. Most Android spyware arrives as an app installed from outside the Play Store. Keep this disabled for every app.

Amnesty's top Android tip

Higher-risk users: Google's free Advanced Protection Program adds the strongest account safeguards (requires a security key or passkey).

If your device is taken, and afterwards



In the moment

- Lock it first if you can. Hard-lock (iPhone) or Lockdown (Android) takes two seconds
- You are not obliged to volunteer your passcode. The law on compelled unlocking is unsettled in many places, so ask for a lawyer where possible
- Note the time, place and identifying details of who took it
- Tell a trusted contact as soon as you can



When you get it back, or do not

- From another device: change your key passwords (email first) and sign out all sessions
- Review connected devices and login activity on your main accounts
- If the phone left your sight, treat it cautiously. Watch for odd behaviour. A factory reset is the clean option
- Free expert help exists: Access Now's Digital Security Helpline and Amnesty's Security Lab (next slide)

One habit per topic, if you remember nothing else



Facial recognition

Assume photos of a protest can be matched later. Blur faces, strip metadata, post with delay.



Secure communications

Move sensitive coordination to Signal. Turn on disappearing messages and Registration Lock.



Social media privacy

Do the 15-minute audit: private account, discoverability off, tag approval, location off, search-engine hiding, 2FA.



Device security

Strong passcode, and practise the two-second hard-lock (iPhone) or Lockdown (Android) until it is automatic.

Trusted resources and help

- **Amnesty International Security Lab: Digital Security Resource Hub**
securitylab.amnesty.org/digital-resources · guidance for civil society, incl. high-risk users; 'Get Help' service for targeted digital attacks
- **CIVICUS: The Global Protest Guide (2026)**
publications.civicus.org · before, during and after protest planning, with digital safety exercises
- **EFF: Surveillance Self-Defense**
ssd.eff.org · plain-language guides, including 'Attending a Protest'
- **Internet Freedom Foundation**
internetfreedom.in · Indian digital rights organisation working on surveillance, censorship and privacy; publishes explainers and legal resources
- **Access Now: Digital Security Helpline**
accessnow.org/help · free, 24/7 rapid-response help for civil society, in nine languages
- **Guardian Project: ObscuraCam**
guardianproject.info · free Android app that blurs faces in photos